

Bear's
breeches

All sorts of flowers

HOW MANY INDIVIDUAL FLOWERS are there on these two pages? The question is not as simple as it sounds. You would need a magnifying glass to work out the answer, because the final figure adds up to at least 3,300. Some plants, such as the tulip, each have just a single flower.

Others, like the dog rose, have a lot of flowers, but each one develops and blooms separately. Many other plants—including most of the plants on these two pages—produce flowers grouped together in clusters known as flower heads. Flower heads have many different shapes, and they vary widely in size and in the number of flowers they contain. The world's biggest individual flower, produced by the giant rafflesia (pp. 44–45), is completely dwarfed by the world's biggest flower head: this is grown by the rare South American puya, which reaches a height of nearly 33 ft (10 m).

Petals fused
to form a
tube

Honeysuckle

Mullein

Rosebay
willowherb

Dog rose

REGULAR FLOWERS

A regular flower, such as the dog rose (see above), has all its parts—sepals, petals, anthers, and stigma—arranged on a simple circular plan.



Tudor
coin

Dog-rose
design

FLOWER SPIRES

Flowers in spires (see left) usually open in sequence, starting at the bottom. This sequence may take a number of weeks to complete. By the time the last flower has opened, the first may already have set seed.

IRREGULAR FLOWERS

An irregular flower, such as the sweet pea, is still symmetrical, but in a more limited way. Most irregular flowers are bilaterally symmetrical, meaning that they can be divided into two halves that are mirror images of each other.

Sepal

Petal

Sweet pea

The iris is a
regular flower
that can be cut
symmetrically
into three pieces

Iris